English–Spanish Glossary

Executive and Virtual Assistance

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US Mainly American English · UK Mainly British English · No label: used in both
AR Argentine Spanish. All other Spanish is neutral Latin American.
⚠ False friend or common trap.

1. VOCABULARY

Office and administrative vocabulary

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL	NOTES
calendar	agenda, calendario	⚠ *agenda* in English means "orden del día"
agenda	orden del día	False friend
schedule	cronograma, horario, agenda	
appointment	cita, turno AR	
meeting	reunión	
all-hands meeting	reunión general	
one-on-one (1:1)	reunión individual	
kickoff meeting	reunión de inicio / de lanzamiento	
recurring meeting	reunión periódica / recurrente	
back-to-back meetings	reuniones seguidas / una tras otra	
minutes	acta, minuta	
action items	tareas pendientes / acciones a seguir	
next steps	próximos pasos	
deadline	fecha límite, plazo	
to-do list	lista de tareas / de pendientes	
backlog	tareas acumuladas / pendientes	
deliverable	entregable	
workflow	flujo de trabajo	
stakeholder	parte interesada	
gatekeeper	filtro (persona que controla el acceso al ejecutivo)	
availability	disponibilidad	
time zone	zona horaria, huso horario	
reminder	recordatorio	
follow-up	seguimiento	
handover	traspaso (de tareas)	
onboarding	incorporación, inducción	

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL	NOTES
inbox	bandeja de entrada	
attachment	archivo adjunto	
out-of-office reply	respuesta automática de ausencia	
template	plantilla	
letterhead	membrete, hoja membretada	
spreadsheet	hoja de cálculo, planilla AR	
shared drive	unidad compartida	
filing system	sistema de archivo	
records	registros, archivos	
invoice	factura	
receipt	recibo, comprobante	
expense report	informe de gastos, rendición de gastos AR	
reimbursement	reembolso, reintegro AR	
budget	presupuesto	
petty cash	caja chica	
purchase order	orden de compra	
vendor / supplier	proveedor	
lead	cliente potencial, prospecto	
pipeline	embudo de ventas, cartera de oportunidades	
board of directors	directorio, junta directiva	
headquarters	sede central, casa matriz	
front desk	recepción	
office supplies	insumos de oficina, artículos de librería AR	
bandwidth	disponibilidad, capacidad (para más trabajo)	Figurative

Travel and logistics

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
travel arrangements	gestión / organización de viajes
itinerary	itinerario
booking / reservation	reserva
layover	escala
boarding pass	tarjeta de embarque
accommodation	alojamiento
ground transportation	traslados terrestres
per diem	viáticos
travel expenses	gastos de viaje

2. VERBS

Core verbs

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
to schedule	programar, agendar
to reschedule	reprogramar
to book	reservar
to move up	adelantar
to push back	posponer, postergar
to block off time	bloquear tiempo en la agenda
to confirm / cancel	confirmar / cancelar
to follow up (on)	hacer seguimiento (de)
to touch base	ponerse en contacto, hablar brevemente
to circle back	retomar (un tema)
to nudge / chase	recordar, insistir
to reach out	contactar, comunicarse
to forward	reenviar
to reply (all)	responder (a todos)
to cc / bcc	poner en copia / en copia oculta
to loop in	incluir (en la conversación)
to draft	redactar un borrador
to proofread	revisar, corregir
to file	archivar
to log	registrar
to track	hacer seguimiento, controlar
to upload / share	subir / compartir
to prioritize	priorizar
to triage	clasificar por prioridad
to delegate / assign	delegar / asignar
to coordinate / arrange	coordinar / organizar
to liaise (with)	actuar de enlace (con)
to screen calls	filtrar llamadas
to take minutes	tomar nota, levantar acta
to handle / manage	gestionar, encargarse de
to submit	presentar, enviar
to approve / sign off	aprobar / dar el visto bueno
to invoice	facturar
to reimburse	reembolsar, reintegrar
to reconcile	conciliar (cuentas)
to escalate	escalar, derivar a un superior

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
to streamline	optimizar, simplificar
to set up	configurar, organizar
to run errands	hacer trámites / mandados
to attend	asistir ⚠ (*to assist* = ayudar)

Calendar and scheduling

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
to set up a meeting	organizar / armar AR una reunión
to send an invite	enviar una invitación
to accept / decline an invite	aceptar / rechazar una invitación
to double-book	superponer citas, agendar dos cosas a la vez
to clear (someone's) calendar	liberar la agenda (de alguien)
to hold (a slot)	reservar (un horario)
to fit (someone) in	hacerle un lugar (a alguien) en la agenda
to wrap up	terminar, cerrar (una reunión)
to run late / run over	atrasarse / extenderse más de lo previsto
to call off	suspender, cancelar

Email and communication

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
to acknowledge (receipt)	acusar recibo
to relay (a message)	transmitir (un mensaje)
to pass along	hacer llegar
to get back to (someone)	responderle / volver a contactar (a alguien)
to reach (someone)	comunicarse con (alguien)
to leave a voicemail	dejar un mensaje de voz
to put (someone) through	pasar / transferir la llamada
to put on hold	poner en espera
to flag (an email)	marcar (un correo)
to archive	archivar
to unsubscribe	darse de baja
to sort / label	clasificar / etiquetar
to mute / snooze	silenciar / posponer (una notificación o correo)
to brief (someone)	poner al tanto, informar (a alguien)
to debrief	hacer un repaso / informe posterior
to clarify	aclarar
to point out	señalar
to bring up	plantear, mencionar (un tema)

Documents and records

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
to fill out (a form)	completar, llenar (un formulario)
to sign / countersign	firmar / refrendar
to scan / print / copy	escanear / imprimir / fotocopiar
to compile	recopilar
to collate	ordenar, cotejar
to format	dar formato
to edit / revise	editar / revisar
to transcribe	transcribir
to back up	hacer una copia de seguridad
to retrieve	recuperar, buscar (un documento)
to keep on file	mantener en archivo
to update records	actualizar los registros
to shred	destruir (documentos)

Tasks and projects

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
to oversee	supervisar
to keep track of	llevar el control de
to stay on top of	estar al día con
to meet (a deadline)	cumplir (un plazo)
to miss (a deadline)	no cumplir (un plazo)
to hand off	traspasar, entregar
to take over	hacerse cargo de
to cover (for someone)	reemplazar (a alguien)
to step in	intervenir, reemplazar
to anticipate	anticiparse a
to troubleshoot	resolver problemas
to sort out	resolver, arreglar
to automate	automatizar
to implement	implementar
to roll out	lanzar, poner en marcha
to wrap up / close out	concluir, finalizar

Finance and purchasing

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
to place an order	hacer un pedido
to request a quote	pedir un presupuesto / una cotización
to process a payment	procesar un pago
to issue (an invoice)	emitir (una factura)

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
to bill	facturar, cobrar
to charge	cobrar
to refund	reembolsar, devolver el dinero
to keep within budget	no salirse del presupuesto
to keep receipts	guardar los comprobantes

People and relationships

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
to greet / welcome	recibir / dar la bienvenida
to introduce	presentar
to network	hacer contactos
to build rapport	generar confianza / buena relación
to accommodate (a request)	atender (un pedido)
to handle confidential information	manejar información confidencial
to represent (the executive)	representar (al ejecutivo)

3. COMMON EXPRESSIONS

Everyday phrases

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
I am reaching out regarding...	Me comunico con respecto a...
I am following up on...	Hago seguimiento de... / Retomo el tema de...
Please find attached...	Adjunto encontrará...
As per our conversation...	Según lo conversado...
Per your request...	Según lo solicitado...
On behalf of [name]...	En nombre de [nombre]...
At your earliest convenience	A la brevedad, cuando le sea posible
Would [time] work for you?	¿Le queda bien [hora]?
Please advise.	Quedo a la espera de sus indicaciones.
Kindly confirm receipt.	Por favor, confirme la recepción.
Just a friendly reminder...	Le recuerdo amablemente que...
I will keep you posted.	Lo mantendré al tanto.
Noted, thank you.	Entendido, gracias.
I will look into it.	Lo voy a revisar.
Heads-up	Aviso previo
It is on my radar.	Lo tengo presente.
Pending approval	Pendiente de aprobación
Going forward...	De ahora en adelante...
Save the date	Reserve la fecha
Tentative (meeting)	Reunión tentativa / a confirmar

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
Thank you for your patience.	Gracias por su paciencia.
Let me know if you have any questions.	Quedo a disposición por cualquier consulta.

Opening an email

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
I hope this email finds you well.	Espero que se encuentre bien.
I am writing on behalf of [name].	Le escribo en nombre de [nombre].
Thank you for reaching out.	Gracias por comunicarse.
Thank you for your prompt reply.	Gracias por su pronta respuesta.
As discussed...	Según lo conversado...
To recap...	A modo de resumen...
I would like to introduce you to...	Me gustaría presentarle a...

Scheduling

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
Are you available on...?	¿Tiene disponibilidad el...?
Please let me know what works best for you.	Indíqueme qué horario le resulta más conveniente.
Here are a few options:	Le propongo algunas opciones:
I have sent you a calendar invite.	Le envié una invitación al calendario.
[Name] has a conflict at that time.	[Nombre] tiene otro compromiso en ese horario.
We need to reschedule.	Necesitamos reprogramar.
I apologize for the short notice.	Disculpe el poco aviso.
Please note the time is in [EST].	Tenga en cuenta que el horario es de [hora del Este].
[Name] is running a few minutes late.	[Nombre] viene con unos minutos de demora.
Looking forward to meeting you.	Quedo a la espera de nuestra reunión.

Requests and follow-ups

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
Could you please...?	¿Podría, por favor...?
I would appreciate it if...	Le agradecería si...
Just checking in on...	Quería consultar cómo va...
I wanted to bring this to your attention.	Quería informarle sobre esto.
Any update on...?	¿Hay novedades sobre...?
We are still waiting on...	Todavía estamos esperando...
This is time-sensitive.	Esto es urgente / tiene plazo.
Please treat this as confidential.	Le pido que trate esto con confidencialidad.
I have taken the liberty of...	Me tomé la libertad de...

Responding and confirming

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
Got it. / Understood.	Entendido.

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
Consider it done.	Cuente con ello.
I am on it.	Ya me estoy encargando.
That works for me.	Me parece bien. / Me queda bien.
All set.	Todo listo.
I have taken care of it.	Ya lo resolví. / Ya me ocupé.
I will get back to you by [time].	Le respondo antes de [hora].
Let me check and get back to you.	Lo consulto y le aviso.
Sorry for the delay in getting back to you.	Disculpe la demora en responder.
Thank you for flagging this.	Gracias por avisarme.

Phone and gatekeeping

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
May I ask who is calling?	¿De parte de quién?
May I ask what this is regarding?	¿Me podría indicar el motivo de la llamada?
[Name] is in a meeting right now.	[Nombre] está en una reunión en este momento.
[Name] is unavailable at the moment.	[Nombre] no está disponible en este momento.
Can I take a message?	¿Quiere dejarle un mensaje?
I will make sure [Name] gets your message.	Me aseguro de que [Nombre] reciba su mensaje.
One moment, please; I will transfer you.	Un momento, por favor; lo comunico.
What is the best number to reach you?	¿A qué número lo podemos contactar?

Closing an email

ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
Please do not hesitate to contact me.	No dude en contactarme.
I look forward to hearing from you.	Quedo a la espera de su respuesta.
Thank you in advance.	Desde ya, muchas gracias.
Have a great rest of your day.	Que tenga un buen resto del día.
Best regards / Kind regards	Saludos cordiales

4. WORKPLACE IDIOMS

Time and deadlines

IDIOM	MEANING	ESPAÑOL
crunch time US	the busy period right before a deadline	la recta final, momento de máxima presión
down to the wire US	until the very last minute	hasta último momento
against the clock	rushing to finish in time	contra reloj
ahead of / behind schedule	earlier / later than planned	adelantado / atrasado
a tight deadline	little time to finish	un plazo ajustado
a hard / soft deadline	a fixed / flexible due date	un plazo inamovible / flexible

IDIOM	MEANING	ESPAÑOL
at the eleventh hour	at the last possible moment	a último momento
in the nick of time	just before it is too late	justo a tiempo
time is of the essence	it is urgent	el tiempo apremia
pressed for time	having very little time	con el tiempo justo, corto de tiempo
on short notice	with little warning (UK: *at* short notice)	con poca anticipación
a quick turnaround	a fast delivery or reply	una entrega / respuesta rápida
in a timely manner	on time, without delay	en tiempo y forma AR, oportunamente
buy (some) time	get more time	ganar tiempo
drag your feet	delay on purpose, be slow to act	demorar, remolonear AR
make up for lost time	catch up after a delay	recuperar el tiempo perdido
on the back burner	set aside for later	en pausa, para más adelante
on the front burner US	top priority	prioridad máxima
around the clock	all day and all night (UK also: *round the clock*)	las 24 horas, sin parar
on the clock US	working, during paid hours	en horario laboral
first thing tomorrow	early tomorrow morning	mañana a primera hora
sooner rather than later	as soon as possible	cuanto antes
moving forward	from now on	de aquí en adelante
call it a day	stop working for the day	dar por terminada la jornada

Communication

IDIOM	MEANING	ESPAÑOL
keep (someone) posted	keep them informed	mantener al tanto
in the loop / out of the loop	informed / not informed	al tanto / desinformado
give (someone) a heads-up US	warn them in advance	avisar con anticipación
get the ball rolling	start something	poner las cosas en marcha
get the word out US	spread the information	difundir, correr la voz
hear it through the grapevine	hear an unofficial rumor	enterarse de rumores, por radio pasillo AR
read between the lines	understand what is implied	leer entre líneas
cut to the chase US	get to the point	ir al grano
beat around the bush US	avoid the point (UK: *beat about the bush*)	andarse con rodeos, dar vueltas
run it by (someone)	check it with someone first	consultarlo con (alguien)
take it offline US	discuss it separately, outside the meeting	hablarlo aparte
a quick sync US	a short catch-up meeting	una reunión rápida de puesta al día
a sounding board	someone to test ideas on	alguien con quien intercambiar ideas

IDIOM	MEANING	ESPAÑOL
put it in writing	document it	dejarlo por escrito
drop (someone) a line	write to them briefly	escribirle unas líneas (a alguien)
ping (someone)	send a quick message (informal)	mandarle un mensaje (a alguien)
hop on a call US	have a quick call (informal)	hacer una llamada rápida
in a nutshell	in short	en pocas palabras, en resumen
touch on (a topic)	mention briefly	mencionar, tocar brevemente (un tema)
get the message across	make yourself understood	transmitir el mensaje, hacerse entender
get your wires crossed	misunderstand each other	malentenderse
pick (someone's) brain	ask an expert for ideas (informal)	consultar a alguien, pedirle su opinión
for the record	so that it is officially noted	para que conste
off the record	unofficially, not to be quoted	extraoficialmente

Decisions and agreement

IDIOM	MEANING	ESPAÑOL
on the same page	in agreement, sharing the same understanding	en sintonía, de acuerdo
a no-brainer US	an obvious decision	algo obvio, una decisión fácil
get the green light	get approval	recibir luz verde
give the go-ahead	approve	dar el visto bueno
on board	in agreement, part of the plan	de acuerdo, comprometido
see eye to eye	agree	coincidir, estar de acuerdo
meet halfway	compromise	llegar a un punto medio
a win-win	good for both sides	beneficio mutuo, todos ganan
call the shots	make the decisions	tomar las decisiones, llevar la batuta
the ball is in your court	it is your turn to act	la pelota está de tu lado, te toca a vos AR
play it by ear	decide as things develop	ir viendo sobre la marcha
sleep on it	wait before deciding	consultarlo con la almohada
a judgment call US	a decision based on your own criteria (UK spelling: *judgement*)	una decisión a criterio propio
on the fence	undecided	indeciso
weigh the pros and cons	compare advantages and disadvantages	sopesar los pros y los contras
have the final say	make the last decision	tener la última palabra
a done deal	already decided or closed	un hecho, un asunto cerrado
jump the gun	act too soon	apresurarse, adelantarse
second-guess US	doubt a decision after making it	cuestionar, dudar de una decisión
go back and forth	keep changing your mind or debating	ir y venir, darle vueltas

IDIOM	MEANING	ESPAÑOL
bite the bullet	do something unpleasant but necessary	hacer de tripas corazón, asumirlo
rubber-stamp	approve without really reviewing	aprobar sin analizar

Work and effort

IDIOM	MEANING	ESPAÑOL
go the extra mile	do more than expected	dar lo mejor de sí, hacer un esfuerzo extra
pull your weight	do your fair share	cumplir con la parte que le toca
hit the ground running	start working well from day one	arrancar con todo desde el primer día
learn the ropes	learn how things work	aprender cómo funcionan las cosas
show (someone) the ropes	train them	enseñarle el funcionamiento a alguien
up to speed	fully informed and caught up	al día, al tanto
get up to speed	catch up	ponerse al día
juggle (tasks)	handle many things at once	hacer malabares con varias tareas
have a lot on your plate	be very busy	tener mucho trabajo encima
swamped	overloaded with work	tapado de trabajo AR, desbordado
wear many hats US	have several roles at once	cumplir varias funciones
burn the midnight oil	work late into the night	quedarse trabajando hasta tarde
burn out	exhaust yourself	agotarse, quemarse
a well-oiled machine	an efficient team or process	una máquina bien aceitada
behind the scenes	out of public view	detrás de escena

Problems and solutions

IDIOM	MEANING	ESPAÑOL
low-hanging fruit	the easiest things to fix or win first	lo más fácil de resolver primero
touch and go	uncertain	incierto
fall through the cracks US	be forgotten or missed (UK: *slip through the net*)	pasarse por alto, quedar en el olvido
put out fires US	deal with urgent problems (UK: *firefighting*)	apagar incendios (resolver urgencias)
a bottleneck	a point that slows everything down	un cuello de botella
a hiccup	a small problem	un inconveniente menor
hit a snag	run into a problem	toparse con un obstáculo
back to square one	start again from the beginning	volver a empezar de cero
back to the drawing board	rethink the plan	replantear desde el principio
a quick fix	a fast, temporary solution	un parche, una solución rápida
think outside the box	think creatively	pensar de forma creativa
a game changer	something that changes everything	algo que cambia las reglas del juego

IDIOM	MEANING	ESPAÑOL
nip it in the bud	stop a problem early	cortarlo de raíz
damage control US	limiting the harm (UK: *damage limitation*)	control de daños
a red flag	a warning sign	una señal de alerta
the bottom line	the essential point or result	lo fundamental, en definitiva

Teams and the office

IDIOM	MEANING	ESPAÑOL
a team player	someone who works well with others	alguien que trabaja bien en equipo
the go-to person US	the one everyone asks	la persona de referencia
a right-hand man / woman / person	a trusted assistant	la mano derecha
a point person US	the person in charge of something	el responsable, la persona de referencia
a dry run	a practice run	un ensayo, una prueba previa
a ballpark figure / estimate US	a rough number or estimate	una cifra aproximada, un cálculo aproximado
raise the bar	set higher standards	subir la vara AR, elevar el estándar
by the book	following the rules exactly	al pie de la letra
cut corners	do something cheaply or carelessly	hacer las cosas a las apuradas, sin cuidado
keep it under wraps	keep it secret	mantenerlo en reserva
a heads-down day US	a day of focused work, no meetings	un día de trabajo concentrado
a busy bee	a very active, hardworking person	alguien muy trabajador / activo

5. ABBREVIATIONS

ABBR.	ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
EA / VA / PA	Executive / Virtual / Personal Assistant	Asistente ejecutivo / virtual / personal
ASAP	As soon as possible	Lo antes posible
EOD	End of day	Al final del día
COB	Close of business	Al cierre de la jornada
EOW / EOM	End of week / month	A fin de semana / de mes
ETA	Estimated time of arrival	Hora estimada de llegada
FYI	For your information	Para su información
FYA	For your action	Para su gestión
OOO	Out of office	Fuera de la oficina
PTO	Paid time off	Días libres pagos, licencia AR
WFH	Working from home	Trabajo desde casa
TBD / TBA	To be determined / announced	A definir / a anunciar

ABBR.	ENGLISH	ESPAÑOL
TBC	To be confirmed	A confirmar
N/A	Not applicable	No corresponde
RSVP	Répondez s'il vous plaît	Confirmar asistencia
CC / BCC	Carbon copy / Blind carbon copy	CC / CCO (con copia oculta)
FW / RE	Forward / Reply	RV (reenviado) / RE
PS	Postscript	P. D.
LMK	Let me know	Avíseme
NRN	No reply needed	No hace falta responder
AOB	Any other business	Varios / otros asuntos
WIP	Work in progress	Trabajo en curso
SOP	Standard operating procedure	Procedimiento operativo estándar
KPI	Key performance indicator	Indicador clave de desempeño
OKR	Objectives and key results	Objetivos y resultados clave
ROI	Return on investment	Retorno de la inversión
SLA	Service level agreement	Acuerdo de nivel de servicio
NDA	Non-disclosure agreement	Acuerdo de confidencialidad
PO	Purchase order	Orden de compra
AP / AR	Accounts payable / receivable	Cuentas por pagar / por cobrar
P&L	Profit and loss	Estado de resultados
YTD / MTD	Year / month to date	En lo que va del año / del mes
Q1–Q4	Quarter 1–4	Primer a cuarto trimestre
POC	Point of contact	Persona de contacto
CRM	Customer relationship management	Gestión de relaciones con clientes
ICP	Ideal customer profile	Perfil de cliente ideal
CEO / COO / CFO	Chief Executive / Operating / Financial Officer	Director/a general / de operaciones / financiero/a
HR	Human resources	Recursos humanos (RR. HH.)

6. FALSE FRIENDS

ENGLISH	CORRECT SPANISH	WATCH OUT
agenda	orden del día	*agenda* (ES) = calendar
to assist	ayudar	*asistir* (ES) = to attend
actually	en realidad	*actualmente* (ES) = currently
eventually	finalmente	*eventualmente* (ES) = possibly
library	biblioteca	*librería* (ES) = bookstore

7. BRITISH ENGLISH

British terms and expressions you may hear from UK clients, with the American equivalent.

Vocabulary

BRITISH	AMERICAN	MEANING	ESPAÑOL
diary	calendar	where appointments are kept	agenda
timetable	schedule	planned times	horario, cronograma
rota	schedule / roster	who works which shift	cronograma de turnos
annual leave / holiday	vacation / PTO	paid time off	vacaciones, licencia AR
holiday cover	vacation coverage	someone doing your job while you are away	reemplazo por vacaciones
bank holiday	public / federal holiday	national day off	feriado
fortnight	two weeks	14 days	quince días, dos semanas
a one-off	a one-time thing	it happens only once	algo excepcional, por única vez
managing director (MD)	CEO	head of the company	director/a general
made redundant	laid off	lost a job because the role was cut	despedido (por reducción de personal)
CV	résumé	job history document	currículum (CV)
mobile	cell phone		celular
post	mail	letters and parcels	correo postal
postcode	ZIP code		código postal
VAT	sales tax	tax added to a price	IVA
lever arch file	binder	large ring file	bibliorato AR, carpeta de anillos
biro	ballpoint pen		birome AR, bolígrafo
Sellotape	Scotch tape		cinta adhesiva
rubber	eraser	⚠ in the US, *rubber* means condom	goma de borrar
the loo / the toilets	the restroom / bathroom		el baño
lift	elevator		ascensor
car park	parking lot		estacionamiento
petrol	gas	fuel (for travel expenses)	nafta AR, combustible
queue	line	people waiting	fila, cola
return / single ticket	round-trip / one-way ticket		pasaje de ida y vuelta / de ida
ground floor / first floor	first floor / second floor	⚠ UK floors start counting one level higher	planta baja / primer piso

BRITISH	AMERICAN	MEANING	ESPAÑOL
18/10/2026	10/18/2026	⚠ UK writes day/month, US writes month/day	18/10/2026

Verbs

BRITISH	AMERICAN	MEANING	ESPAÑOL
to ring / give (someone) a ring	to call	phone someone	llamar
to ring back	to call back	return a call	devolver la llamada
to diarise	to put on the calendar	add to the schedule	agendar
to book in	to schedule	set an appointment	agendar, programar
to chase up	to follow up	remind someone who has not replied	hacer seguimiento, insistir
to post	to mail	send by post	enviar por correo
to fill in (a form)	to fill out	complete	completar
to tick (a box)	to check (a box)	mark	marcar (una casilla)
to collect (someone)	to pick up	go and get someone	pasar a buscar (a alguien)
to pop in / pop by	to stop by	visit briefly	pasar un momento
to table (a topic)	to bring up	⚠ UK: put it up for discussion. US *to table* means **postpone**	UK: proponer, poner sobre la mesa / US: postergar
to queue	to wait in line		hacer fila
to hire (a car)	to rent		alquilar
to reckon	to think / figure	to believe or estimate	creer, calcular
to fancy	to feel like	to want	tener ganas de
to get on (with someone)	to get along	have a good relationship	llevarse bien
to have a word (with someone)	to talk to someone	often to correct a problem	hablar con alguien (para corregir algo)
to faff about	to mess around	waste time on small things	perder el tiempo, dar vueltas

Expressions

BRITISH	AMERICAN	MEANING	ESPAÑOL
Many thanks. / Cheers.	Thanks so much. / Thanks.	thank you (*cheers* is informal)	Muchas gracias. / Gracias.
Kind regards	Best regards / Best	email sign-off	Saludos cordiales
Shall we say 3 pm?	Does 3 pm work?	proposing a time	¿Le parece a las 15?
half three	three thirty	⚠ 3:30, not 2:30	las tres y media
I am afraid...	Unfortunately...	softens bad news	Lamentablemente...
Not to worry.	No worries. / No problem.	it is fine	No hay problema.
Who is speaking, please?	Who is calling?	asking the caller's name	¿De parte de quién?

BRITISH	AMERICAN	MEANING	ESPAÑOL
Hold the line, please.	Please hold.	wait on the phone	Aguarde en línea, por favor.
Sorry, I did not quite catch that.	Sorry, I did not get that.	asking someone to repeat	Disculpe, no lo escuché bien.
Speak soon.	Talk soon.	goodbye	Hablamos pronto.
Brilliant! / Lovely!	Great! / Awesome!	very good	¡Excelente! / ¡Genial!
Are you alright?	How are you? / Hi!	⚠ a greeting, not real concern	¿Cómo está? / ¡Hola!
Sorry?	Excuse me? / Pardon?	asking someone to repeat	¿Perdón? / ¿Cómo?
Leave it with me.	I will take care of it.	I am responsible for it now	Déjelo en mis manos.
No bother.	No problem.	it is fine, happy to help	No hay problema.
I will pop it in the post.	I will mail it.		Se lo envío por correo.
Sorted!	All set! / Done!	the problem is solved	¡Listo! / ¡Resuelto!

Reception and phone phrases (medical practice)

BRITISH	AMERICAN	MEANING	ESPAÑOL
Are you registered with the practice?	Are you an existing patient?	practice = the clinic	¿Es paciente del consultorio?
Could I take your NHS number?	Could I get your insurance information?	NHS = UK public health system	¿Me da su número de afiliado / de seguro?
I can book you in with the duty doctor.	I can schedule you with the on-call doctor.		Le puedo dar turno AR con el médico de guardia.
The doctor is out on a home visit.	The doctor is out on a house call.		El médico está haciendo una visita a domicilio.
Your results have come back.	Your results are in.		Ya están sus resultados.
If it gets worse, go to A&E or ring 999.	If it gets worse, go to the ER or call 911.	A&E = emergency room	Si empeora, vaya a la guardia o llame al número de emergencias.

General idioms

BRITISH	AMERICAN	MEANING	ESPAÑOL
a spanner in the works	a wrench in the works	something that ruins a plan	algo que arruina los planes
touch wood	knock on wood	said for luck	toquemos madera
a storm in a teacup	a tempest in a teapot	a big fuss about nothing	una tormenta en un vaso de agua
sweep under the carpet	sweep under the rug	hide a problem	barrer bajo la alfombra
skeleton staff	skeleton crew	the minimum number of people working	personal mínimo, guardia mínima
go pear-shaped	go south / go sideways	go wrong	salir mal, irse al diablo
at sixes and sevens	all over the place	disorganized	desorganizado, un caos

BRITISH	AMERICAN	MEANING	ESPAÑOL
go round the houses	beat around the bush	take too long to get to the point	dar vueltas, irse por las ramas
a damp squib	a dud / a letdown	a disappointing failure	un fiasco, una decepción
on the back foot	on the defensive	at a disadvantage	a la defensiva
a dab hand (at)	a pro (at)	very skilled	un experto (en), muy hábil (para)
Bob's your uncle	and there you go	and that is it, simple	y listo
a different kettle of fish	a whole different ball game	something completely different	otra cosa muy distinta
not my cup of tea	not my thing	not something I like	no es lo mío
a doddle	a piece of cake / a breeze	very easy	pan comido
pull your socks up	step it up / shape up	improve your work	ponerse las pilas
taking the mickey	pulling someone's leg	joking, making fun	tomar el pelo
chuffed (to bits)	thrilled	very pleased	contentísimo
gutted	bummed / devastated	very disappointed	muy desilusionado
cost a bomb	cost a fortune	very expensive	costar un ojo de la cara
go down a storm / a bomb	be a hit	⚠ a big success. In US English, *to bomb* means to fail	ser un éxito
kick off	blow up	⚠ UK: get angry, make a scene. US: start	armarse lío, enojarse / US: empezar
send (someone) to Coventry	give (someone) the silent treatment	ignore someone on purpose	aplicar la ley del hielo
on the blower	on the phone	(informal)	al teléfono

Idioms for work, teams and decisions

BRITISH	AMERICAN	MEANING	ESPAÑOL
a safe pair of hands	a reliable person	someone you can trust with important work	alguien de confianza
be across (something)	be on top of (something)	fully informed and in control of it	estar al tanto, tenerlo bajo control
get your skates on	get a move on	hurry up	apurarse
put (something) to bed	wrap (something) up	finish it, close it for good	dar por cerrado
a sticking-plaster solution	a Band-Aid solution	a quick, temporary fix	un parche
box-ticking	checking boxes / going through the motions	doing something only to meet a rule	cumplir por cumplir
sing from the same hymn sheet	be on the same page	everyone says and does the same thing	estar en sintonía, hablar con una sola voz
keep (someone) in the picture	keep (someone) in the loop	keep them informed	mantener al tanto

BRITISH	AMERICAN	MEANING	ESPAÑOL
muck in	pitch in	help with the work, even simple tasks	colaborar, dar una mano
joined-up thinking	big-picture thinking	planning where all parts fit together	pensamiento integrado, visión de conjunto
get the nod	get the go-ahead	get approval	recibir el visto bueno
a U-turn	a flip-flop / a reversal	a complete change of decision	un cambio de postura, marcha atrás
kick (something) into the long grass	shelve (something)	delay a decision with no plan to return to it	cajonear AR, dejar en el olvido
move the goalposts	change the rules midstream	change the conditions after work has started	cambiar las reglas de juego
horses for courses	it depends on the situation	different options suit different cases	cada caso es distinto
a talking shop	all talk and no action	a meeting with discussion but no decisions	reunión donde se habla y no se decide

Polite British code

BRITISH	AMERICAN	WHAT IT REALLY MEANS	ESPAÑOL
With the greatest respect…	I disagree…	⚠ I think you are wrong	Con todo respeto… (desacuerdo)
That is an interesting idea.	Hmm, I am not sure about that.	⚠ often: I do not like it	Interesante… (no me convence)
I will bear it in mind.	I will think about it.	⚠ often: probably not	Lo tendré en cuenta (probablemente no)
Not bad.	Pretty good.	it is actually good	Nada mal. / Bastante bien.
quite good	pretty good / okay	⚠ *quite* often means "fairly", not "very"	bastante bien (sin entusiasmo)
I almost agree.	I do not really agree.	⚠ I do not agree at all	Casi de acuerdo (en realidad, no)
Perhaps you would like to…	Please…	⚠ this is an instruction	Quizás quiera… (= hágalo)
I only have a few minor comments.	I have some feedback.	⚠ it may need a big rewrite	Solo unos comentarios menores (= hay que rehacerlo)
Correct me if I am wrong…	I think…	⚠ I am sure I am right	Corríjame si me equivoco… (= tengo razón)

Spelling

BRITISH	AMERICAN	ESPAÑOL
organise	organize	organizar
prioritise	prioritize	priorizar
authorise	authorize	autorizar
analyse	analyze	analizar

BRITISH	AMERICAN	ESPAÑOL
cancelled	canceled	cancelado
travelling	traveling	viajando
labelled	labeled	etiquetado
programme	program	programa
centre	center	centro
catalogue	catalog	catálogo
cheque	check	cheque
licence *(noun)*	license	licencia
enquiry	inquiry	consulta
fulfil	fulfill	cumplir
judgement	judgment	criterio, juicio
acknowledgement	acknowledgment	acuse de recibo, reconocimiento